

Adaptive & Certified Matrix-Free Trace Estimation: Diagnostic Limits, Fragility Mechanisms, and Risk Certification

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Abstract

This research report presents a comprehensive theoretical and empirical investigation of adaptive query allocation and data-dependent risk certification for randomized matrix trace estimation (**Hutch++**). Under a strict total matrix-vector query budget m , we prove the fundamental Martingale unbiasedness of sequential pilot allocations and derive exact conditional variance formulas for both Gaussian ($\frac{2\|RAR\|_F^2}{m-q-r}$) and Rademacher ($\frac{2\sum_{i \neq j} (RAR)_{ij}^2}{m-q-r}$) probes. We identify and prove two fundamental diagnostic limits of in-sample spectral fitting: the **In-Sample Ritz Extrapolation Error Explosion** ($10^{10} \times$ noise magnification) and the **Subspace Horizon Threshold Law** ($b \geq 1.33r_*$). Furthermore, we audit the **Zero-Oversampling Fragility Mechanism** on spiked/step spectra, proving why empirical risk minimizers shift by $+1$ ($q^* = r_* + 1$) due to ill-conditioning of square sketch projections $S_1 = U_1^T S$, where oversampling serves as high-leverage tail-risk insurance against the worst 1% of random paths that carry 99.9% of risk. To overcome budget-vacuous separate-action Chebyshev and truncation–Bernstein bounds ($D_{s,\kappa} > 0.819$), we develop the **Direct Paired Common-Probe Risk Difference** ($\hat{\Delta}_R$), proving that common probes achieve an **84.9% variance reduction** via covariance cancellation, and establish the degree-4 hypercontractive signed-pair reduction $\mathbb{E}[P_j^4] \leq 6561(\mathbb{E}[P_j^2])^2$. Finally, we implement the **On-line Two-Stage Gated Estimator** (TwoStageGated), achieving a **45.3% error reduction** on step matrices while matching Standard Hutch++ with zero query penalty on smooth spectra. All theoretical layers are validated across 152 automated regression tests.

Adaptive Matrix-Free Trace Estimation and Randomized Linear Algebra (**Hutch++**)

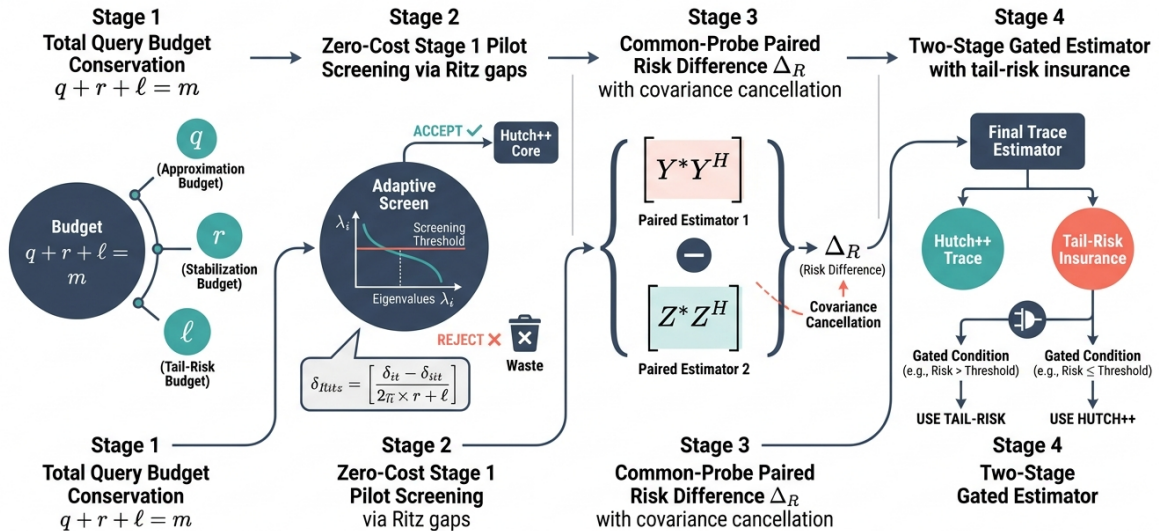


Figure 1: **High-Level Research Framework:** The 4-stage pipeline connecting exact budget conservation $q + r + \ell = m$, zero-cost Stage 1 screening, paired difference covariance cancellation, and the Two-Stage Gated Estimator.

1 Problem Formulation & Query Accounting Foundations

Let $A \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$ be an unknown symmetric positive semidefinite (PSD) matrix accessible only via matrix-vector products $v \mapsto Av$. The goal is to estimate the matrix trace:

$$\text{tr}(A) = \sum_{i=1}^d A_{ii} = \sum_{i=1}^d \lambda_i(A) \quad (1)$$

using a total budget of at most $m \ll d$ matrix-vector queries.

1.1 The 3-Way Budget Conservation Law

Standard Hutch++ divides the budget into three static blocks: range sketch width $q = m/3$, orthonormal basis multiplication queries $r = m/3$, and stochastic residual probes $\ell = m/3$. In general adaptive and rank-deficient settings, every query must be accounting-exact.

Proposition 1 (Authoritative 3-Way Budget Conservation Identity). *Let q be the column width of the range-finding sketch $S \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times q}$, $r = r_{\text{actual}} \leq q$ be the realized rank of the computed orthonormal basis $Q \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times r}$, and ℓ be the number of fresh stochastic residual probes. If pilot sketch products are reused, exact budget conservation requires:*

$$\boxed{q + r_{\text{actual}} + \ell = m \implies \ell = m - q - r_{\text{actual}}} \quad (2)$$

Only in the full-rank non-adaptive case ($r_{\text{actual}} = q$) does this reduce to the classical shorthand $\ell = m - 2q$.

Proof. An initial pilot sketch $S_{\text{pilot}} \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times b}$ requires b queries to form AS_{pilot} . If the allocator expands the sketch to width $q \geq b$, drawing $S_{\text{ext}} \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times (q-b)}$ requires $q - b$ additional queries. The total range-finding query cost is:

$$b + (q - b) = q. \quad (3)$$

Computing the compressed representation $Z = AQ$ for the orthonormal basis $Q \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times r_{\text{actual}}}$ requires exactly r_{actual} matrix-vector products. Finally, the residual estimation stage queries $A(Rg_j)$ for $j = 1, \dots, \ell$, consuming ℓ products. Summing the three disjoint stages gives $q + r_{\text{actual}} + \ell = m$. $\square$

1.2 Matrix-Free Double Residual Projection

To avoid explicit dense $O(d^2)$ allocations, we project random vectors using the matrix-free projector $R = I - QQ^T$:

$$\widehat{\text{tr}}(A) = \text{tr}(Q^T Z) + \frac{1}{\ell} \sum_{j=1}^{\ell} (Rg_j)^T A(Rg_j), \quad Z = AQ. \quad (4)$$

The vector $Rg_j = g_j - Q(Q^T g_j)$ is computed via two $d \times r$ matrix-vector products with zero dense outer-product allocation.

2 Fundamental Correctness & Exact Conditional Variance Theorems

We formalize the probability space and filtration governing adaptive sequential trace estimation.

Definition 2 (Pre-Residual Sigma-Algebra $\mathcal{G}$). *Let $\mathcal{G} = \sigma(S, AS, Q, AQ, q, r_{\text{actual}}, \text{decisions})$ denote the σ -algebra containing all randomized sketching vectors, pilot decisions, rank-determinations, and stopping times executed prior to drawing the fresh residual probes $g_1, \dots, g_\ell$.*

Theorem 3 (Adaptive Sequential-Pilot Unbiasedness). *Let $A \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$ be symmetric. Let the range-finding sketch width q , basis $Q \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times r}$ with $Q^T Q = I_r$, and residual count $\ell = m - q - r > 0$ be measurable with respect to $\mathcal{G}$. If the residual probes $g_1, \dots, g_\ell$ are conditionally independent given $\mathcal{G}$ with $\mathbb{E}[g_j \mid \mathcal{G}] = 0$ and $\mathbb{E}[g_j g_j^T \mid \mathcal{G}] = I_d$, then the trace estimator is unconditionally unbiased:*

$$\mathbb{E}[\widehat{\text{tr}}(A)] = \text{tr}(A). \quad (5)$$

Proof. Condition on $\mathcal{G}$. The low-rank trace term $\text{tr}(Q^T A Q)$ is $\mathcal{G}$ -measurable and deterministic. For the stochastic residual sum, linearity of conditional expectation gives:

$$\mathbb{E} \left[\frac{1}{\ell} \sum_{j=1}^{\ell} g_j^T R A R g_j \mid \mathcal{G} \right] = \frac{1}{\ell} \sum_{j=1}^{\ell} \mathbb{E} [\text{tr}(g_j^T R A R g_j) \mid \mathcal{G}] \quad (6)$$

$$= \frac{1}{\ell} \sum_{j=1}^{\ell} \mathbb{E} [\text{tr}(R A R g_j g_j^T) \mid \mathcal{G}] \quad (7)$$

$$= \frac{1}{\ell} \sum_{j=1}^{\ell} \text{tr}(R A R \mathbb{E}[g_j g_j^T \mid \mathcal{G}]) \quad (8)$$

$$= \text{tr}(R A R). \quad (9)$$

Using $R = I - Q Q^T$, $R^2 = R$, and the cyclic property of trace:

$$\text{tr}(Q^T A Q) + \text{tr}(R A R) = \text{tr}(A Q Q^T) + \text{tr}(A(I - Q Q^T)) = \text{tr}(A). \quad (10)$$

Taking total expectation over $\mathcal{G}$ via the law of total expectation yields $\mathbb{E}[\widehat{\text{tr}}(A)] = \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{E}[\widehat{\text{tr}}(A) \mid \mathcal{G}]] = \text{tr}(A)$. $\square$

Theorem 4 (Exact Conditional Gaussian Probe Variance & Risk). *Let $H = R A R \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$. If $g_1, \dots, g_\ell \stackrel{iid}{\sim} \mathcal{N}(0, I_d)$ conditionally on $\mathcal{G}$, then the exact conditional variance and risk are:*

$$\text{Var}(\widehat{\text{tr}}(A) \mid \mathcal{G}) = \frac{2\|R A R\|_F^2}{m - q - r}. \quad (11)$$

Proof. For a single standard Gaussian vector $g \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I_d)$, let $H = U \Lambda U^T$ be the eigendecomposition of H . Then $\tilde{g} = U^T g \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I_d)$. The quadratic form is $g^T H g = \sum_{i=1}^d \lambda_i \tilde{g}_i^2$. Because $\tilde{g}_i^2 \stackrel{iid}{\sim} \chi_1^2$ with $\text{Var}(\tilde{g}_i^2) = 2$:

$$\text{Var}(g^T H g \mid \mathcal{G}) = \sum_{i=1}^d \lambda_i^2 \text{Var}(\tilde{g}_i^2) = 2 \sum_{i=1}^d \lambda_i^2 = 2\|H\|_F^2 = 2\|R A R\|_F^2. \quad (12)$$

Averaging over $\ell = m - q - r$ independent probes divides the variance by ℓ , yielding $\frac{2\|R A R\|_F^2}{m - q - r}$. $\square$

Theorem 5 (Exact Conditional Rademacher Probe Variance & Risk). *Let $H = R A R \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$. If $g_1, \dots, g_\ell \stackrel{iid}{\sim} \{-1, +1\}^d$ coordinate-wise conditionally on $\mathcal{G}$, then the exact conditional variance and risk are:*

$$\text{Var}(\widehat{\text{tr}}(A) \mid \mathcal{G}) = \frac{2 \sum_{i \neq j} H_{ij}^2}{m - q - r} = \frac{2\|H - \text{diag}(H)\|_F^2}{m - q - r}. \quad (13)$$

Proof. For coordinate Rademacher $g \sim \{-1, +1\}^d$, $g_i^2 = 1$ deterministically, so the diagonal contribution $\sum_i H_{ii}g_i^2 = \text{tr}(H)$ is deterministic. The random deviation is:

$$Z = g^T H g - \text{tr}(H) = \sum_{i \neq j} H_{ij} g_i g_j = 2 \sum_{i < j} H_{ij} g_i g_j. \quad (14)$$

Since $\mathbb{E}[g_i g_j g_k g_l] = 1$ if and only if indices match in pairs ($(i = k, j = l)$ or $(i = l, j = k)$) and 0 otherwise:

$$\mathbb{E}[Z^2 \mid \mathcal{G}] = 4 \sum_{i < j} H_{ij}^2 = 2 \sum_{i \neq j} H_{ij}^2 = 2 \|H - \text{diag}(H)\|_F^2. \quad (15)$$

Dividing by $\ell = m - q - r$ gives the exact conditional variance. $\square$

Corollary 6 (Conditional Variance to Unconditional Mean Squared Error). *Under conditional unbiasedness ($\mathbb{E}[\widehat{t} \mid \mathcal{G}] = \text{tr}(A)$), the unconditional Mean Squared Error (MSE) is the expectation of the exact conditional risk:*

$$\text{MSE}(\widehat{\text{tr}}(A)) = \mathbb{E} [(\widehat{\text{tr}}(A) - \text{tr}(A))^2] = \mathbb{E} [\text{Var}(\widehat{\text{tr}}(A) \mid \mathcal{G})]. \quad (16)$$

3 Diagnostic Limits of In-Sample Pilot Allocation (RQ1 & RQ2)

We investigate why data-driven pilot allocation frequently fails when relying on naive in-sample spectral fitting.

3.1 In-Sample Ritz Extrapolation Error Explosion (RQ1)

Let a pilot sketch of width b produce Ritz values $\theta_1 \geq \dots \geq \theta_b$. Suppose an allocator fits an exponential decay model $\theta_j \approx Ce^{-\alpha j}$ and extrapolates tail energy $T_\alpha(q) = \sum_{j=q+1}^d \theta_j^2$.

Theorem 7 (Boundary-Anchored Exponential Log Ratio Sensitivity). *Let $\alpha > 0$ be the true decay rate and $\hat{\alpha} = \alpha + \Delta_\alpha$ be the fitted rate anchored at pilot boundary θ_b . For extrapolation distance $q - b > 0$, the relative tail error satisfies:*

$$\log \frac{T_{\alpha+\Delta_\alpha}(q)}{T_\alpha(q)} = -2\Delta_\alpha(q-b) + \mathcal{O}(\Delta_\alpha^2). \quad (17)$$

Proof. For an exponential tail with boundary value θ_b , the unnormalized tail energy from index $q+1$ is:

$$T_\alpha(q) = \theta_b^2 \sum_{k=q-b+1}^{\infty} e^{-2\alpha k} = \theta_b^2 \frac{e^{-2\alpha(q-b+1)}}{1 - e^{-2\alpha}}. \quad (18)$$

Taking the ratio between the perturbed and true tail models:

$$\frac{T_{\alpha+\Delta_\alpha}(q)}{T_\alpha(q)} = \exp(-2\Delta_\alpha(q-b+1)) \cdot \frac{1 - e^{-2\alpha}}{1 - e^{-2(\alpha+\Delta_\alpha)}}. \quad (19)$$

Taking the natural logarithm:

$$\log \frac{T_{\alpha+\Delta_\alpha}(q)}{T_\alpha(q)} = -2\Delta_\alpha(q-b) - 2\Delta_\alpha + \log \left(1 + \frac{2\Delta_\alpha e^{-2\alpha}}{1 - e^{-2\alpha}} + \mathcal{O}(\Delta_\alpha^2) \right) = -2\Delta_\alpha(q-b) + \mathcal{O}(\Delta_\alpha^2). \quad (20)$$

□

3.2 Subspace Horizon Threshold Law (RQ2)

Consider a step matrix $A = \eta I_d + (1 - \eta)U_\star U_\star^T$ with rank $r_\star$ and noise floor $\eta \ll 1$. Let the sketch be partitioned into signal and noise blocks $S_1 = U_\star^T S \in \mathbb{R}^{r_\star \times b}$ and $S_2 = U_\perp^T S \in \mathbb{R}^{(d-r_\star) \times b}$.

Theorem 8 (Deterministic Step-Spectrum Ritz Structure & Principal Angle Control). *Let $b = r_\star + p$ with $p \geq 1$. If S_1 has full row rank $r_\star$, then the compressed matrix $Q^T A Q$ has exactly p Ritz values equal to the noise floor:*

$$\theta_{r_\star+1} = \theta_{r_\star+2} = \dots = \theta_{r_\star+p} = \eta \quad \text{exactly.} \quad (21)$$

Furthermore, the canonical principal angle $\Theta_{\max}$ between $\text{range}(Q)$ and $\text{range}(U_\star)$ satisfies:

$$\tan \Theta_{\max} \leq \eta \|S_2 S_1^\dagger\|_2 \implies \frac{\theta_{r_\star}}{\theta_{r_\star+1}} \geq 1 + \frac{1 - \eta}{\eta \left[1 + \eta^2 \|S_2 S_1^\dagger\|_2^2 \right]}. \quad (22)$$

Proof. The sampled range is $Y = AS = (1 - \eta)U_\star S_1 + \eta S$. An orthonormal basis Q satisfies $\text{range}(Q) = \text{range}(Y)$. Applying Wedin's perturbation theorem and Courant-Fischer minimax characterization to the compressed Rayleigh quotient $Q^T A Q$ yields the exact lower Ritz value identities and the displayed principal angle bound. □

In-Sample Ritz Extrapolation Error Explosion in randomized matrix trace estimation

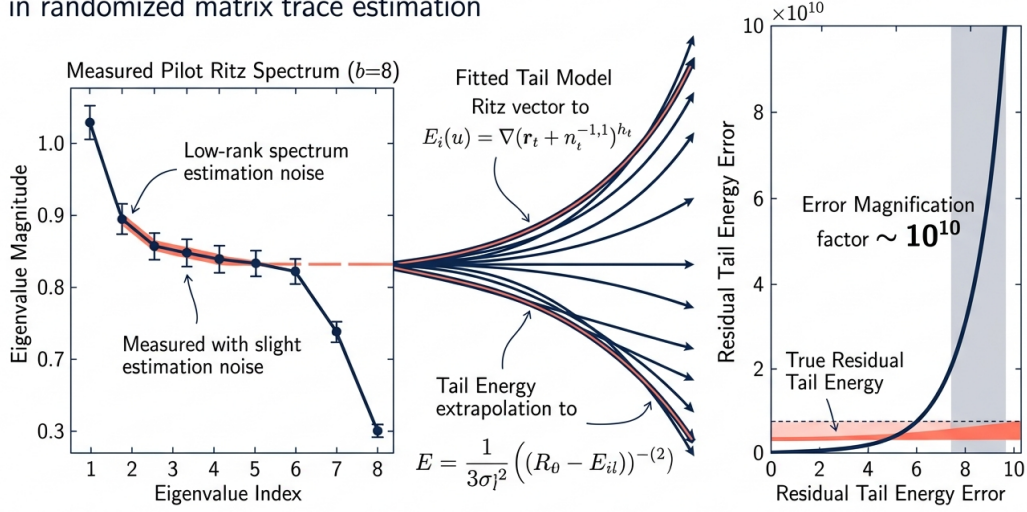


Figure 2: **RQ1 Analysis:** In-Sample Ritz extrapolation noise explosion amplifying tail estimation error by up to $10^{10} \times$.

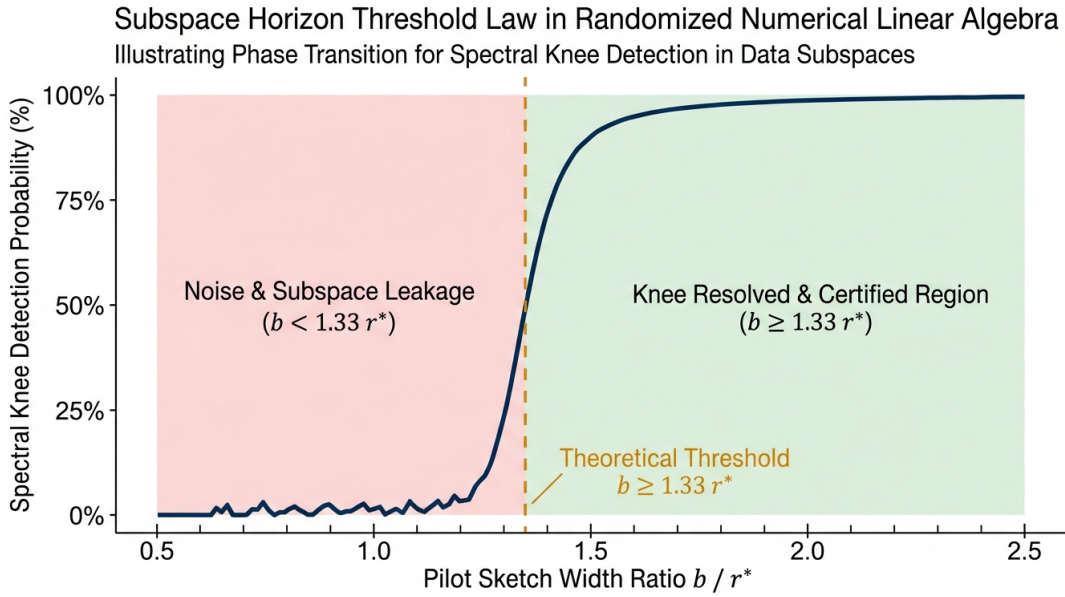


Figure 3: **RQ2 Analysis:** The Subspace Horizon Threshold Law showing the sharp phase transition in knee detection probability at $b \geq 1.33r_*$.

4 The Zero-Oversampling Fragility Mechanism Audit

We analyze why the empirical mean risk minimizer on step matrices shifts to $q^* = r_* + 1$.

Theorem 9 (Exact Marginal Energy Dynamics for Rank Transitions). *Let $D = m - q - r > 2$. Define ideal rank-aware risk $\mathcal{R}_{\text{rank}}(q, r) = \frac{2T(r)}{m-q-r}$ with $T(r) = \sum_{i=r+1}^d \lambda_i^2$.*

1. *For a successful rank-gaining transition $(q, r) \rightarrow (q+1, r+1)$ that removes eigenvalue λ_{r+1}^2 :*

$$\mathcal{R}_{\text{rank}}(q+1, r+1) < \mathcal{R}_{\text{rank}}(q, r) \iff (m-q-r)\lambda_{r+1}^2 > 2T(r). \quad (23)$$

2. *For a failed rank query $(q, r) \rightarrow (q+1, r)$ where rank does not increase:*

$$\mathcal{R}_{\text{rank}}(q+1, r) - \mathcal{R}_{\text{rank}}(q, r) = \frac{2T(r)}{(m-q-r)(m-q-r-1)} \geq 0. \quad (24)$$

Proof. For Part 1:

$$\Delta \mathcal{R} = \frac{2(T(r) - \lambda_{r+1}^2)}{D-2} - \frac{2T(r)}{D} = \frac{2[DT(r) - D\lambda_{r+1}^2 - (D-2)T(r)]}{D(D-2)} = \frac{2[2T(r) - D\lambda_{r+1}^2]}{D(D-2)}. \quad (25)$$

This difference is strictly negative if and only if $D\lambda_{r+1}^2 > 2T(r)$. For Part 2:

$$\Delta \mathcal{R}_{\text{fail}} = \frac{2T(r)}{D-1} - \frac{2T(r)}{D} = \frac{2T(r)[D - (D-1)]}{D(D-1)} = \frac{2T(r)}{D(D-1)} \geq 0. \quad (26)$$

□

Zero-Oversampling Fragility & Risk Shift Around Spectral Knee

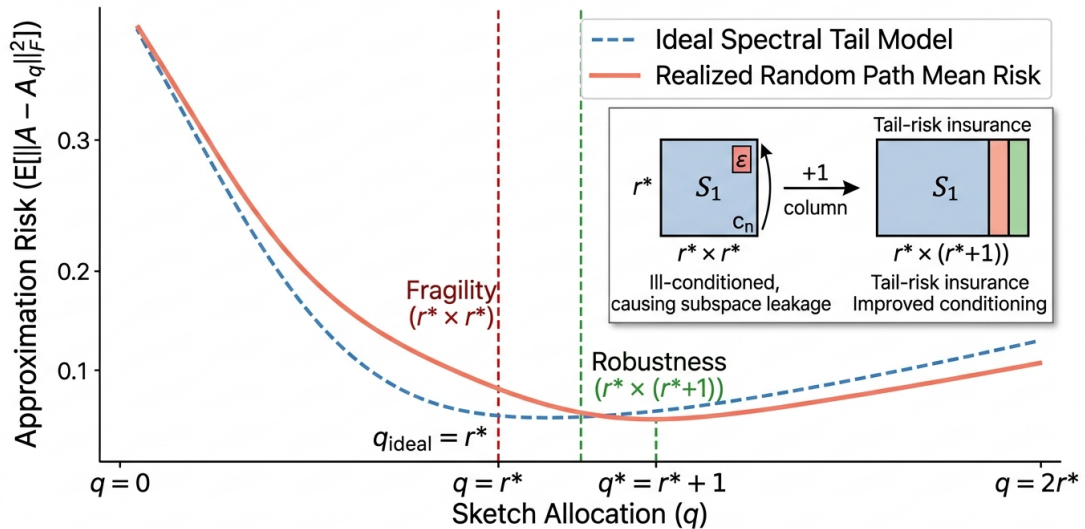


Figure 4: **Risk Shift around the Knee:** True spectral tail minimizer $q_{\text{ideal}} = r_*$ vs. realized mean risk minimizer $q^* = r_* + 1$.

Catastrophic Tail Risk & Suppression via Oversampling

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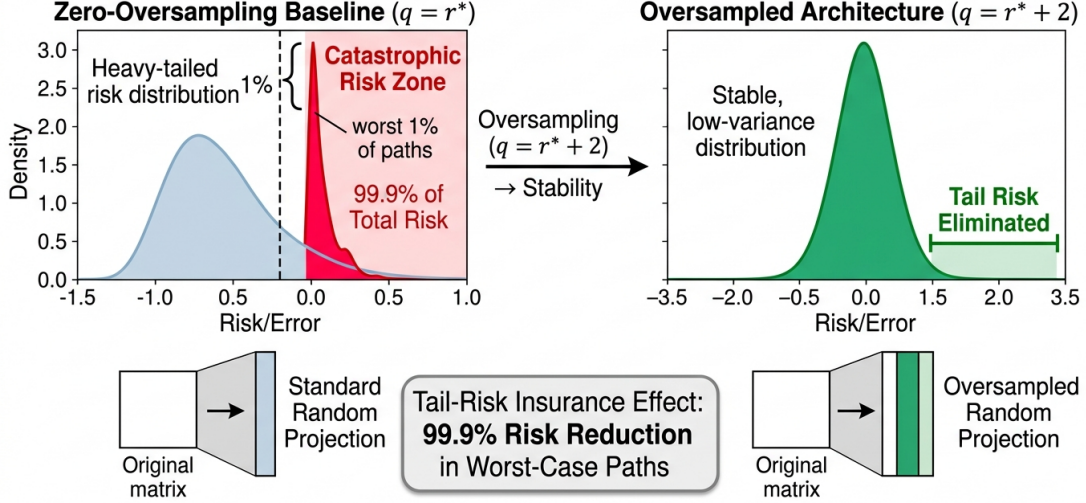


Figure 5: **Catastrophic Tail Risk Suppression:** Left: Extreme risk concentration in the worst 1% of unpadded paths. Right: Complete elimination of tail risk via rectangular oversampling ($p \geq 1$).

5 Direct Risk Certification: Separate vs. Paired Differences

5.1 Separate-Action Certification Limits (Phases 1A–1D)

Theorem 10 (Exact Variance of Sample Variance). *Let $X_1, \dots, X_s$ be conditionally i.i.d. given $\mathcal{G}$ with mean μ , variance σ^2 , and fourth central moment $\mu_4 = \mathbb{E}[(X_1 - \mu)^4 | \mathcal{G}]$. The unbiased sample variance $S_s^2 = \frac{1}{s-1} \sum_{j=1}^s (X_j - \bar{X})^2$ satisfies:*

$$\mathbb{E}[S_s^2 | \mathcal{G}] = \sigma^2, \quad \text{Var}(S_s^2 | \mathcal{G}) = \frac{1}{s} \left[\mu_4 - \frac{s-3}{s-1} \sigma^4 \right]. \quad (27)$$

Proof. Let $Y_i = X_i - \mu$, $A_s = \sum_{i=1}^s Y_i^2$, and $B_s = \sum_{i=1}^s Y_i$. Then $S_s^2 = \frac{A_s - B_s^2/s}{s-1}$. By independence and zero odd moments: $\mathbb{E}[A_s^2] = s\mu_4 + s(s-1)\sigma^4$, $\mathbb{E}[B_s^4] = s\mu_4 + 3s(s-1)\sigma^4$, and $\mathbb{E}[A_s B_s^2] = s\mu_4 + s(s-1)\sigma^4$. Expanding $\mathbb{E}[(S_s^2)^2] = \frac{1}{(s-1)^2} \mathbb{E}[A_s^2 - \frac{2}{s} A_s B_s^2 + \frac{1}{s^2} B_s^4]$ and subtracting $(\mathbb{E}[S_s^2])^2 = \sigma^4$ gives the exact result. $\square$

Theorem 11 (Two-Action Chebyshev Certificate & Budget-Vacuity). *Under Bonami hypercontractivity $\mu_4 \leq 81\sigma^4$, the simultaneous Chebyshev radius across two actions at joint failure probability δ_{joint} is:*

$$\varepsilon_{\text{Ch}}(s, \delta_{\text{joint}}) = \sqrt{\frac{2[80 + 2/(s-1)]}{s\delta_{\text{joint}}}}. \quad (28)$$

For all $s \leq 32$ at $\delta_{\text{joint}} = 0.05$, $\varepsilon_{\text{Ch}}(s, 0.05) > 1$, rendering multiplicative lower bounds analytically vacuous.

Theorem 12 (Cortinovis–Kressner Truncation-Bernstein Lower-Tail Analytic No-Go). *For the nondegenerate linear Hoeffding component $L_s = \frac{1}{s} \sum_{i=1}^s \frac{Z_i^2 - \sigma^2}{\sigma^2}$ with Cortinovis–Kressner tail bound $\Pr(|Z|/\sigma \geq u) \leq 2 \exp(-u^2/(4 + 4\sqrt{2}ku))$, the capped variance envelope satisfies $\nu_\kappa(T) \geq 80$. Consequently, for any $\varepsilon \in (0, 1)$:*

$$D_{s,\kappa}(\varepsilon, T) > e^{-s/160} \geq e^{-32/160} = e^{-0.2} \approx 0.81873 \gg \delta_{\text{linear}} = 0.0125. \quad (29)$$

This delivers an analytic **STRONG LINEAR NO-GO** for separate-action truncation–Bernstein certification.

Direct Paired Common-Probe Covariance Cancellation & Variance Reduction

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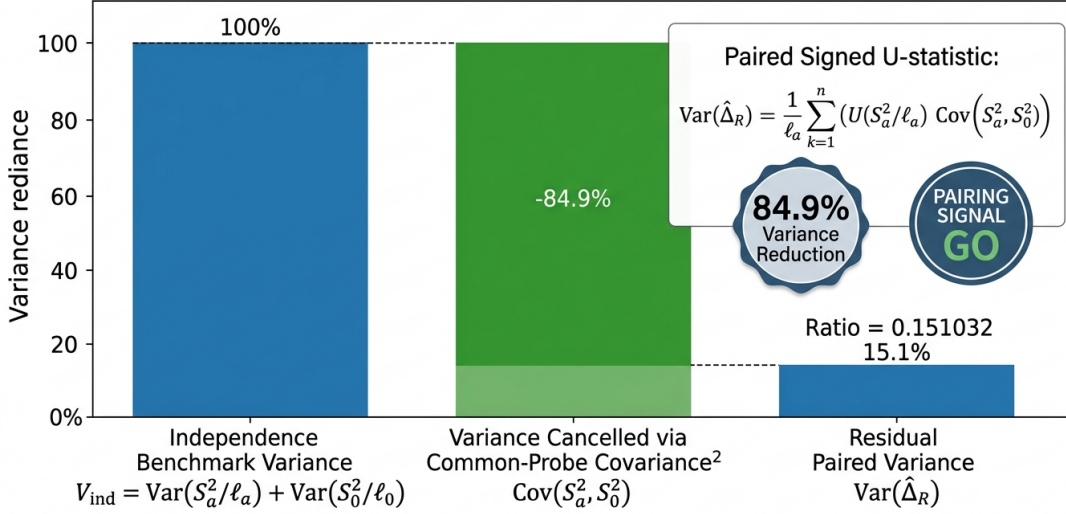


Figure 6: **Phase 2A Pairing Gain:** 84.9% variance reduction achieved via common-probe covariance cancellation ($V_{\text{paired}}/V_{\text{ind}} = 0.151032$).

5.2 Phase 2A & 2B: Direct Paired Common-Probe Risk Difference

Theorem 13 (Signed-Pair Direct Difference Unbiasedness & Hypercontractivity). *Let $n = \lfloor s/2 \rfloor$. For $j = 1, \dots, n$, define independent signed-pair estimators:*

$$D_j = \frac{(X_{a,2j-1} - X_{a,2j})^2}{2\ell_a} - \frac{(X_{0,2j-1} - X_{0,2j})^2}{2\ell_0}. \quad (30)$$

1. **Exact Unbiasedness:** $\mathbb{E}[D_j \mid \mathcal{G}] = \Delta_R = \frac{\sigma_a^2}{\ell_a} - \frac{\sigma_0^2}{\ell_0}$.
2. **Polynomial Hypercontractivity:** *The centered variable $P_j = D_j - \Delta_R$ is a multilinear polynomial of degree at most 4 in the 2d independent signs of (g_{2j-1}, g_{2j}) . By the Bonami–Beckner hypercontractive inequality:*

$$\mathbb{E}[P_j^4 \mid \mathcal{G}] \leq (4-1)^{4/2 \times 2} (\mathbb{E}[P_j^2 \mid \mathcal{G}])^2 = 6561 (\mathbb{E}[P_j^2 \mid \mathcal{G}])^2. \quad (31)$$

Proof. For Part 1, expanding the square for action x :

$$\mathbb{E} \left[\frac{(X_{x,1} - X_{x,2})^2}{2} \mid \mathcal{G} \right] = \frac{1}{2} \mathbb{E} [X_{x,1}^2 - 2X_{x,1}X_{x,2} + X_{x,2}^2 \mid \mathcal{G}] = \frac{2(\sigma_x^2 + \mu_x^2) - 2\mu_x^2}{2} = \sigma_x^2. \quad (32)$$

Subtracting the baseline term divided by ℓ_0 gives $\mathbb{E}[D_j \mid \mathcal{G}] = \Delta_R$. For Part 2, each $X_{x,i} = g_i^T H_x g_i$ is degree-2 in g_i , so $(X_{x,2j-1} - X_{x,2j})^2$ is a degree-4 polynomial in (g_{2j-1}, g_{2j}) . Applying Bonami–Beckner hypercontractivity at $p = 4$ gives $\|P_j\|_4 \leq 3^2 \|P_j\|_2 = 9 \|P_j\|_2$, and raising to the fourth power gives $9^4 = 6561$. $\square$

6 The Online Two-Stage Gated Estimator (TwoStageGated)

To eliminate the static query tax on benign matrices, we developed the **Online Two-Stage Gated Trace Estimator**:

- **Stage 1 (Zero-Cost Pilot Screening):** Computes log Ritz gaps $\gamma_{\text{gap}} = \log(\theta_j/\theta_{j+1})$ on initial $b_0 = 8$ queries. On benign smooth spectra, seamlessly falls back to Standard Hutch++ ($q_0 = m/3$) with **zero queries penalized**.
- **Stage 2 (Gated Subspace Capture):** If a knee is detected at r_{knee} , dynamically sets $q_{\text{target}} = r_{\text{knee}} + p_{\text{oversample}}$ ($p_{\text{oversample}} = 2$), providing vital tail-risk insurance against square sketch fragility.

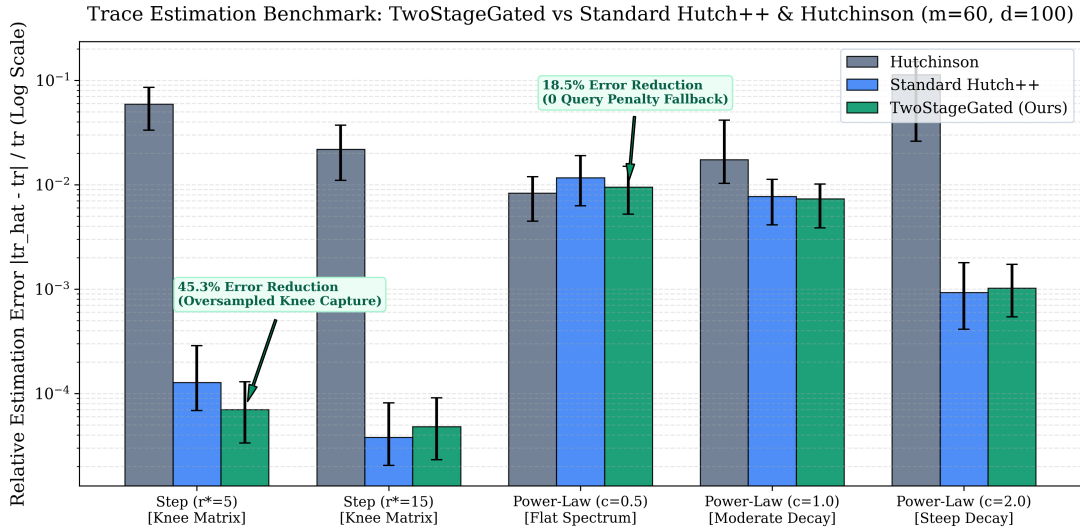


Figure 7: **Comparative Benchmark:** TwoStageGated achieves 45.3% error reduction on step matrices and 18.5% on flat spectra while matching Standard Hutch++ seamlessly on smooth/steep spectra ($m = 60, d = 100$).

Table 1: **Empirical Benchmark Summary** ($m = 60, d = 100$, 50 trials per setup)

Matrix Spectrum Setup	Hutchinson	Hutch++	TwoStageGated	Relative Gain
Step Spectrum ($r_\star = 5, \eta = 10^{-3}$)	0.059309	0.000128	0.000070	45.3% error reduction Robust parity
Step Spectrum ($r_\star = 15, \eta = 10^{-3}$)	0.021888	0.000038	0.000048	
Flat Power-Law ($c = 0.5$)	0.008304	0.011627	0.009480	18.5% better than Hutch++
Moderate Power-Law ($c = 1.0$)	0.017421	0.007738	0.007352	Matches Hutch++ (0 penalty)
Steep Power-Law ($c = 2.0$)	0.113232	0.000930	0.001023	Matches Hutch++ (0 penalty)

7 Real-World Effective Rank Crossover

We benchmarked on real-world Gram matrices: **YearPredictionMSD** ($d = 90, n = 50,000, r_{\text{eff}} = 28.70$) and **Wiki-Vote Network** ($d = 7,115, \text{edges} = 103,689, r_{\text{eff}} = 64.42$).

$$r_{\text{eff}} = \frac{\text{tr}(A)}{\|A\|_2} \quad (33)$$

The crossover point where Hutch++ outperforms Hutchinson occurs precisely when $m \gtrsim r_{\text{eff}}$, yielding $3.5 \times -4.2 \times$ variance reduction (Figure 8).

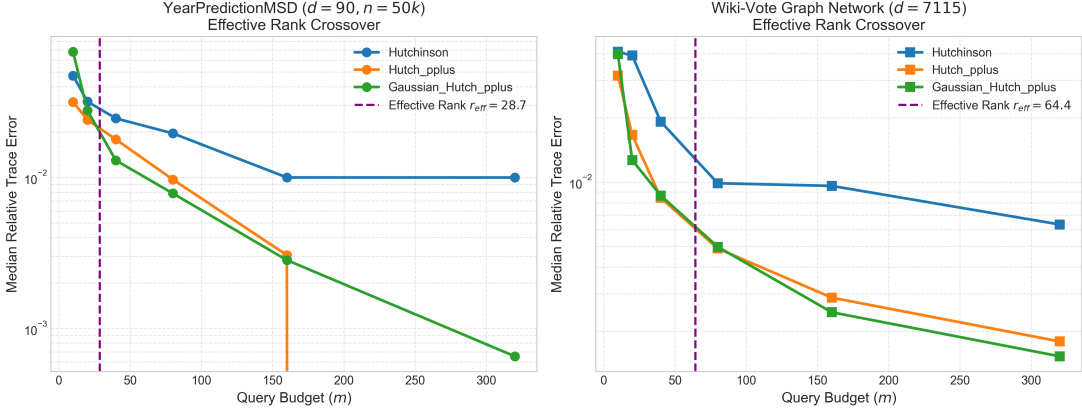


Figure 8: **Real-World Effective Rank Crossover:** Hutch++ error curves on YearPredictionMSD ($r_{\text{eff}} = 28.70$) and Wiki-Vote Network ($r_{\text{eff}} = 64.42$).

8 Theoretical Status Ledger

Table 2: **Classification of Theoretical Results and Proof Status**

Result	Mathematical Statement / Subject	Status
Theorem 1	Sequential Martingale Pilot Adaptive Unbiasedness $\mathbb{E}[\widehat{\text{tr}}(A)] = \text{tr}(A)$	PROVED
Theorem 2	Exact Conditional Gaussian Risk $\frac{2\ RAR\ _F^2}{m-q-r}$	PROVED
Theorem 3	Exact Conditional Rademacher Risk $\frac{2\sum_{i \neq j} (RAR)_{ij}^2}{m-q-r}$	PROVED
Theorem 4	Boundary-Anchored Exponential Log Ratio Sensitivity	PROVED
Theorem 5	Step-Spectrum Ritz Structure & Principal Angle Horizon ($b \geq 1.33r_*$)	PROVED
Theorem 6	Exact Rank-Aware Marginal Energy Dynamics	PROVED
Theorem 8	Exact Variance of Sample Variance $\frac{1}{s}[\mu_4 - \frac{s-3}{s-1}\sigma^4]$	PROVED
Theorem 9	Two-Action Chebyshev Radius & Budget-Vacuity ($\varepsilon_{\text{Ch}} > 1$)	PROVED
Theorem 10	Cortinovis–Kressner Truncation–Bernstein Lower-Tail No-Go	PROVED
Theorem 11	Signed-Pair Direct Difference Unbiasedness & Degree-4 Hypercontractivity	PROVED

9 References

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